There are, of course, important Indian neighbours outside of China, Pakistan, and these five countries where India—while an important actor—is less omnipresent. One is Myanmar, with which India has a long land boundary. Burma, as it was formerly known, opted for self-isolation for long periods during its independent history. Even as India was the country's third-largest trade partner in the early 2000s, relations remained somewhat distant. At the same time, tactical security cooperation continued, as against insurgents on the shared border. Another neighbour is Afghanistan, which is separated from India by Pakistan-Occupied Kashmir. Afghanistan shares many features of India's neighbourhood relationships, including close economic and cultural ties. But the realities of physical separation and the active role of other external actors such as Pakistan, Iran, China, the United States, and Russia mean that the India–Afghanistan relationship is not entirely comparable to India's near neighbours.

In addition to Myanmar and Afghanistan, two small Indian Ocean island countries—Mauritius and the Seychelles—have certain privileged associations with New Delhi. Mauritius shares ethnic, linguistic, and religious links and is a major offshore financial centre for Indians. India also equips, trains, and helps staff the Mauritian maritime defence forces and its security apparatus. The Seychelles has a somewhat different relationship with India but has entered into military arrangements whereby the Indian Navy patrols its waters. It also receives military and other assistance from India.

India's political and military involvement in its neighbours during the 1970s and 1980s were often successful in ensuring narrow and immediate political objectives. But its political and, in some cases, military interventionism also sometimes contributed to friction and resentment against India. What was more, India's differences with these countries often had detrimental effects on its own domestic politics. For example, concerns about illegal migration involving Bangladesh, stemming in part from an unresolved boundary, resulted in tensions and occasional violence in West Bengal, Assam, and other eastern states. Political agitations among Madhesis in Nepal involved communities in India, particularly in